'Really? Are you sure there isn't one nought too many?'

Albie Morkel had been sold to the Chennai Super Kings (CSK) for US$675 000 per year. Jacques Kallis was going to a team called Royal Challengers Bangalore for a salary of US$900 000 per year.

My immediate response to being contracted for this amount of money was to think, well, I had better play well and score some runs, but, in that first season, the IPL regulation that franchises could sign up to eight overseas players but were allowed to include only four in any starting XI meant I would get few opportunities.

Shoaib Malik, the gifted Pakistan batsman, was usually preferred to me, and I spent most of my time training and travelling, trying to be useful, desperately wanting to prove my value to the team. I played in only three matches but, even so, enjoyed being around players such as Gautam Gambhir and Virender Sehwag, whose brilliant form carried us to the semifinal, where we lost to Rajasthan Royals, the eventual winners.

The average crowd in that first season of IPL cricket was an incredible 58 000 spectators per match. Amid all the jingles, the imported cheerleaders and the shiny kit, the gentleman's game was being turned upside down.

In 2009, concerns that the Indian government could not guarantee security during the run-up up to the general election persuaded the BCCI to make a dramatic decision; barely three weeks before the opening match, they decided that the entire tournament would be moved to South Africa. The logistical challenge was unprecedented, but it was met by the combined skill, can-do mentality and enthusiasm of South Africa's stadium owners, hotel chains, security officials, transport providers, media organisations and supporters. As a country, we made a plan.

The switch in venue was good news for the South African economy, which benefited from an injection of around US$90 million, and it was also good news for me. The Delhi Daredevils coaches knew I would bring local knowledge, and I played in every match, scoring an unbeaten century against CSK in Durban and averaging 45.